

BIG CAT RESCUE

Wild Cat Map Update Guide



Everything you need to add new projects, update donations, change images, and keep the map current — all through your Google Sheet.

OVERVIEW

How the map stays updated

The map reads your Google Sheet automatically every time someone loads the page. You never need to touch the HTML file or GitHub again. The only things you manage are the **Google Sheet** (for project data) and **GitHub** (for images).

THE GOLDEN RULE

Make your changes in the Google Sheet → save → done. The map updates for every visitor within seconds. No HTML, no GitHub, no Claude needed for data changes.

TASK 1

Update an existing project

Use this when a project's donation amount changes, you add a new funded year, or need to update any other detail.

- 1 Go to [your Google Sheet](#) and find the project's row (use ⌘+F to search by name)
- 2 Click the cell you want to change and edit it directly
- 3 Press **Enter** or click away — Google Sheets saves automatically
- 4 The map will show your changes the next time someone loads it (no further action needed)

TIP — UPDATING DONATION TOTALS

The **Donated** column should contain the total cumulative amount donated to that project across all years (a plain number, no \$ sign or commas). The **Years** column can list all funded years separated by commas, e.g. *2020, 2022, 2023*.

TASK 2

Add a new project

Scroll to the bottom of the sheet and fill in a new row. The map will automatically place a pin and add it to the species legend.

- 1 Scroll to the last row in your Google Sheet and click the first empty cell in column A
- 2 Fill in each column (see the **Column Reference** table below)
- 3 The most important columns are **Name**, **Country**, **Category**, and **Donated** — the map needs these to place the pin correctly
- 4 If the project is in a country already on the map, the pin will appear automatically. If it's a new country not yet on the map, let me know and I'll add the coordinates.

NEW COUNTRY?

The map has geocoding (location lookup) for 42 countries already. If you fund a project in a new country not on the current list, the pin won't appear until the country is added to the map code. Just send me a message and I'll update it quickly.

REFERENCE

Column reference

Column	Required?	What to put here
Name	Required	The project name as it should appear on the map

Column	Required?	What to put here
Country	Required	The country name exactly as it appears in other rows (e.g. United States, South Africa)
Category	Required	The species in ALL CAPS (see Species List below). Determines pin color and legend placement.
Donated	Required	Total amount donated — numbers only, no \$ or commas. Example: 5000
City	Optional	City name. Helps place the pin more precisely within a country
State	Optional	State, province, or region
Description	Optional	The full project description shown in the detail panel when someone clicks the pin. Can be as long as needed.
Years	Optional	Year(s) funded. Example: 2023 or 2021, 2022, 2023
Website	Optional	Full URL including https://. Example: https://www.example.org
Organization	Optional	The organization running the project
Photo URL	Optional	Full image URL (see Image section below for how to get this)
YouTube	Optional	YouTube video ID only — the short code after ?v= in a YouTube link. Example: for youtube.com/watch?v=K1AWJnV0sog just put K1AWJnV0sog

REFERENCE

Valid species names for Category

The Category column must match one of these exactly (all caps) or the pin will appear in a default blue color instead of its species color.

AFRICAN GOLDEN CAT

AMUR LEOPARD

ANDEAN CAT

BLACK FOOTED CAT

BOBCAT

CANADA LYNX

CARACAL	CHEETAH	CLOUDED LEOPARD
COUGAR	FISHING CAT	FLAT HEADED CAT
GEOFFREY CAT	GOLDEN CAT	GUIGNA
IBERIAN LYNX	JAGUAR	JAGUARUNDI
JUNGLE CAT	LEOPARD	LION
MARBLED CATS	MARGAY	OCELOT
ONCILLA	PALLAS CAT	PAMPAS CAT
RANGERS	RUSTY SPOTTED CAT	SAND CAT
SMALL CATS	SNOW LEOPARD	TIGER
TIGER CAT		

WATCH OUT FOR TYPOS

The category must match exactly — FISHING CAT works but Fishing Cat or FISHINGCAT will not get the right color. When in doubt, copy and paste from an existing row.

TASK 3

Add or change a project image

Images for the map are hosted in your GitHub repository. Adding a new image is a two-part process: upload the image file to GitHub, then put its URL in the Google Sheet.

1

Prepare your image

JPG or PNG format. Aim for around 800×500 pixels. Rename the file to something simple with no spaces, e.g. *corbett-tiger-2024.jpg*

2

Upload to GitHub

Go to github.com/BigCatRescue/map → Add file → Upload files → drag your image → Commit changes

3

Paste URL in Sheet

Put the full GitHub image URL in the **Photo URL** column for that project row

The image URL follows this pattern — replace **yourfilename.jpg** with whatever you named your file:

```
https://bigcatrescue.github.io/map/yourfilename.jpg
```

Example: If you upload a file called `ocelot-mexico-2025.jpg`, the Photo URL to paste in the sheet is:

```
https://bigcatrescue.github.io/map/ocelot-mexico-2025.jpg
```

CHANGING AN EXISTING PROJECT'S IMAGE

Upload the new image to GitHub (step 2 above), then in the Google Sheet find the project row and replace the old Photo URL with the new one. The old image file can be left on GitHub or deleted — it won't cause any harm either way.

IMAGE TIPS

Use a descriptive filename — it makes future management easier. Avoid spaces in filenames (use hyphens instead). JPG files are smaller and load faster; use PNG only if you need a transparent background.

TASK 4

Add a YouTube video to a project

When a project card is clicked, a video thumbnail will appear if a YouTube ID is in the sheet. You only need the short video ID, not the full link.

- 1 Go to the YouTube video and look at the URL in your browser. It looks like:
`https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=K1AWJnV0sog`
- 2 Copy just the part after `?v=` — in this example: `K1AWJnV0sog`
- 3 In your Google Sheet, find the project row and paste that short code into the **YouTube** column

NO FULL URLS IN THE YOUTUBE COLUMN

The YouTube column expects only the short video ID (the random-looking letters and numbers), not the full youtube.com link. Putting the full URL there will cause the video thumbnail not to appear.

Quick checklist — adding a new project

- ✓ Name filled in
- ✓ Category in ALL CAPS
- ✓ Description written
- ✓ Years listed
- ✓ Image uploaded to GitHub
- ✓ YouTube ID added (if applicable)
- ✓ Country spelled correctly
- ✓ Donated is a plain number
- ✓ Website starts with https://
- ✓ Organization filled in
- ✓ Photo URL pasted in sheet
- ✓ Map checked in browser

IF SOMETHING BREAKS

Troubleshooting

FIRST, FIGURE OUT: IS IT THE MAP OR IS IT YOUR BROWSER?

Open the map in a different browser (Safari, Comet, Firefox — any one you don't normally use). If it works there, the map itself is healthy and the problem is your usual browser's graphics. If it fails in every browser, the problem is in the map's data or code.

Problem: blank/black screen — "Failed to initialize WebGL"

The globe is drawn with WebGL, your computer's 3D graphics engine. If WebGL isn't running, the globe can't draw and you get a black screen — even though the map itself is fine. This is almost always a stuck browser graphics process, not a problem with the map.

The fixes, easiest first:

- 1 **Restart your computer.** This is the #1 fix. WebGL "disabled or unavailable" when it worked before almost always means the graphics process got stuck, and a restart resets it. Try this first.
- 2 **Test if WebGL is working:** go to `get.webgl.org` in your browser. A spinning cube = WebGL is working. An error message = WebGL is stuck (do the restart).
- 3 **Check hardware acceleration is on (Chrome):** Chrome menu → Settings → System → turn ON "Use graphics acceleration when available" → Relaunch.
- 4 **Force a fresh graphics process:** open **Activity Monitor** (⌘+Space, type "Activity Monitor"), search `GPU`, find any stuck "Google Chrome Helper (GPU)" and quit it — or just fully quit Chrome (⌘+Q) and reopen. If there's NO Chrome GPU process listed at all, that's the problem — restart fixes it.

Problem: map loads but a project is missing or in the wrong place

This is a data issue in the Google Sheet, not a code issue. Check that the row has Name, Country, and Category filled in. If a pin is in the wrong spot, the Country/State spelling may not match the map's location table, or you can add exact Latitude and Longitude columns to that row to place it precisely.

Problem: donation total shows \$0 for a species

The Donated column can have dollar signs and commas (the map strips them automatically) — but the cell must be only a number, with no extra text like "total:" mixed in.

REFERENCE

How the map is built (for any future fixes)

If you ever need help from Claude or a developer, share this — it's the whole picture in one place.

Live map URL	https://bigcatrescue.github.io/map/
GitHub repo	https://github.com/BigCatRescue/map — holds <code>index.html</code> + all project images at the root
Google Sheet (data)	The live data source. Edit the sheet → the map updates. Published as CSV, and that CSV URL is hardcoded near the top of <code>index.html</code> .
Map engine	Mapbox GL JS v3.6.0 — this is what draws the 3D globe. (We tried MapLibre first; its globe doesn't work reliably. Mapbox is what EarthTeam uses and what finally worked.)
Mapbox token	A public token (starts with <code>pk.</code>) embedded in <code>index.html</code> , restricted to <code>bigcatrescue.github.io</code> and <code>bigcatrescue.org</code> URLs in the Mapbox account. GitHub may warn it's "exposed" — that's expected and safe because of the URL restriction.
Globe	Set via <code>projection: 'globe'</code> in the Mapbox map constructor, with <code>setFog()</code> for the space/atmosphere look. The Globe/Map button at the bottom toggles between sphere and flat.
Images	Hosted at the GitHub repo root. New images: upload to the repo, then put <code>https://bigcatrescue.github.io/map/filename.jpg</code> in the sheet's Photo URL column.

Geocoding

Pins are placed by, in priority order: explicit Latitude/Longitude columns → city → US state → international state/province → country center. Tables for all this live inside index.html.

ONE-LINE SUMMARY TO PASTE TO CLAUDE IN A NEW CHAT

"My BCR wild cat map is at bigcatrescue.github.io/map/, built with Mapbox GL JS, hosted on GitHub (repo: BigCatRescue/map), reading live from a published Google Sheet CSV. index.html holds the map; images are at the repo root. Here's what's wrong: [describe it]."

Big Cat Rescue Wild Cat Conservation Map · Built with Claude · [View Live Map](#)